



“... I preferred
love to wedlock,
**freedom to
a bond.**”

HÉLOÏSE D'ARGENTEUIL'S THOUGHTS ON MARRIAGE AND CHILDREN, IN THE FIRST LETTER TO PETER ABELARD

SPURNING CONVENTION

Héloïse d'Argenteuil was a 12th-century French nun and scholar. Her correspondence in the form of letters to her husband and former tutor Peter Abelard, a monk, chronicle their tragic love story. The letters are noted for Héloïse's erudition and her disdain for convention, and have found a place in feminist literary history. Despite having wed to satisfy social mores, Héloïse wrote that she would still prefer to be Abelard's mistress. She felt theirs was an ideal union to which marriage added nothing, and personally viewed marriage to be a form of contractual prostitution through which a woman might become richer. Héloïse saw her love for Abelard (pictured left, tutoring her) as pure, in the sense that she loved him for himself rather than anything he could give her.